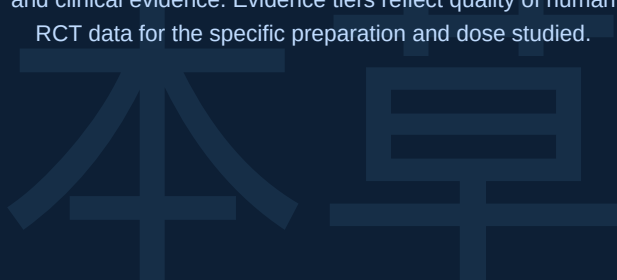


Materia Medica Sinensis

A Clinical Compendium

Integrating traditional classification with modern pharmacology and clinical evidence. Evidence tiers reflect quality of human RCT data for the specific preparation and dose studied.



48 entries -- 34 single herbs -- 9 classical formulas -- 5 patent medicines

S

单味

Single Herbs

Individual materia medica entries

34 entries

Rén Shēn 人參

Panax ginseng (radix)

Single Herb

Tonify Qi

Taste: Sweet, slightly bitter ■■■ | Temp: Slightly warm ■■ | Chan: Lung, Spleen, Heart ■■■

Greatly tonifies original qi; rescues collapse

EVIDENCE

Cancer-related fatigue

MODERATE

Erectile dysfunction

MODERATE

Type 2 diabetes (glycaemia)

LIMITED

Cognitive performance (acute)

LIMITED

Huáng Qí 黄芪

Astragalus membranaceus (radix)

Single Herb

Tonify Qi

Taste: Sweet ■ | Temp: Slightly warm ■■ | Chan: Lung, Spleen ■■

Tonifies spleen/lung qi, raises yang, stabilizes exterior

EVIDENCE

Chemotherapy adjunct (platinum-based)

MODERATE

Chronic heart failure (adjunct)

LIMITED

Diabetic nephropathy

LIMITED

URTI prevention

LIMITED

Dang Shen 党参

Codonopsis pilosula (radix)

Single Herb

Tonify Qi

Taste: Sweet ■ | Temp: Neutral ■ | Chan: Lung, Spleen ■■

Mild qi tonic — "poor man's ginseng"

EVIDENCE

General fatigue / convalescence

INSUFFICIENT

Functional dyspepsia

INSUFFICIENT

Gan Cao 甘草

Glycyrrhiza uralensis (radix et rhizoma)

Single Herb

Tonify Qi

Taste: Sweet ■ | Temp: Neutral ■ (raw) / Warm (honey-fried)

Harmonizes all herbs; tonifies qi; clears heat-toxin; stops cough

EVIDENCE

Peptic ulcer / dyspepsia (DGL)

MODERATE

Aphthous ulcers (topical)

MODERATE

Chronic hepatitis B/C (IV glycyrrhizin)

MODERATE

Eczema (topical glycyrrhetic acid)

LIMITED

Dāng Guī 当归

Angelica sinensis (radix)

Single Herb Tonify Blood

Taste: Sweet, pungent ■■ | Temp: Warm ■ | Chan: Liver, Heart, Spleen ■■■

Tonifies and moves blood; regulates menstruation

EVIDENCE

Menopausal vasomotor symptoms (alone)	NEGATIVE
Primary dysmenorrhoea (in formulas)	LIMITED
Iron-deficiency anaemia (Dang Gui Bu Xue Tang)	LIMITED

Shú Dì Huáng 熟地黄

Rehmannia glutinosa (radix preparata)

Single Herb Tonify Blood

Taste: Sweet ■ | Temp: Slightly warm ■■ | Chan: Liver, Kidney ■■

Tonifies blood and kidney yin

EVIDENCE

Yin-deficiency syndromes (formulas)	INSUFFICIENT
Anaemia (in formulas)	INSUFFICIENT

G■u Q■ Z■ 枸杞子

Lycium barbarum (fructus)

Single Herb

Tonify Yin

Taste: Sweet ■ | Temp: Neutral ■ | Chan: Liver, Kidney, Lung ■■■

Tonifies liver-kidney yin; brightens vision

EVIDENCE

Macular protection (dietary)

LIMITED

General antioxidant / fatigue

LIMITED

D■ng Chóng Xià C■o 冬虫夏草

Ophiocordyceps sinensis (parasitised larva); cultivated...

Single Herb

Tonify Yang

Taste: Sweet ■ | Temp: Warm ■ | Chan: Lung, Kidney ■■

Tonifies kidney yang and lung yin; stops bleeding; resolves phlegm

EVIDENCE

Chronic kidney disease (adjunct)

LIMITED

Post-renal-transplant adjunct

LIMITED

Athletic performance / VO2max

LIMITED

Sexual dysfunction

INSUFFICIENT

Huáng Lián 黄连

Coptis chinensis (rhizoma)

Single Herb

Clear Heat

Taste: Bitter ■ | Temp: Cold ■ | Chan: Heart, Spleen, Stomach, Liver, Gallbladder, LI ■■■■■■

Drains fire, clears heat, dries dampness, resolves toxin

EVIDENCE

Type 2 diabetes (berberine)

STRONG

Dyslipidaemia (berberine)

STRONG

IBS (berberine)

MODERATE

PCOS (insulin resistance)

MODERATE

Huáng Qín 黄芩

Scutellaria baicalensis (radix)

Single Herb

Clear Heat

Taste: Bitter ■ | Temp: Cold ■ | Chan: Lung, Gallbladder, Stomach, LI ■■■■■■

Clears heat, drains fire (especially upper jiao); calms ascending liver yang; calms fetus

EVIDENCE

Adjunct for chemotherapy GI toxicity (PHY906)

LIMITED

Atopic dermatitis (Zemaphyte / multi-herb)

LIMITED

Hepatitis B/C transaminitis

LIMITED

Jīn Yín Huā 金银花

Lonicera japonica (flos)

Single Herb

Clear Heat

Taste: Sweet ■ | Temp: Cold ■ | Chan: Lung, Heart, Stomach ■■■

Clears heat, resolves toxin; releases wind-heat exterior

EVIDENCE

Acute URTI / pharyngitis (Yin Qiao San)

LIMITED

COVID-19 (in Lianhua Qingwen)

LIMITED

Chuān Xīn Lián 穿心莲

Andrographis paniculata (herba)

Single Herb

Clear Heat

Taste: Bitter ■ | Temp: Cold ■ | Chan: Lung, Stomach, Large/Small Intestine ■■■■■

Clears heat-toxin; relieves fire; dries dampness

EVIDENCE

Uncomplicated upper respiratory infection

MODERATE

Ulcerative colitis (mild-moderate)

LIMITED

Multiple sclerosis fatigue

LIMITED

Dān Shēn 丹参

Salvia miltiorrhiza (radix et rhizoma)

Single Herb

Move Blood

Taste: Bitter ■ | Temp: Slightly cold ■■ | Chan: Heart, Pericardium, Liver ■■■■

Invigorates and cools blood; eliminates blood stasis; calms spirit

EVIDENCE

Stable angina (Compound Danshen Dripping Pill)

MODERATE

Acute ischaemic stroke (adjunct)

LIMITED

Diabetic retinopathy

LIMITED

Chronic hepatitis B fibrosis

LIMITED

Sān Qī 三七

Panax notoginseng (radix)

Single Herb

Stop Bleeding

Taste: Sweet, slightly bitter ■■■ | Temp: Warm ■ | Chan: Liver, Stomach ■■

Stops bleeding without causing stasis; transforms blood stasis; reduces swelling and pain

EVIDENCE

Surgical haemostasis (Yunnan Baiyao)

MODERATE

Stable angina / coronary heart disease (adjunct)

MODERATE

Acute ischaemic stroke recovery

LIMITED

Shān Zhǎ 山楂

Crataegus pinnatifida (fructus)

Single Herb

Move Blood

Taste: Sour, sweet ■■ | Temp: Slightly warm ■■ | Chan: Spleen, Stomach, Liver ■■■

Resolves food stagnation (esp. meat/fat); transforms blood stasis

EVIDENCE

Hyperlipidaemia (modest)

LIMITED

Functional dyspepsia after rich meals

INSUFFICIENT

Chái Hú 柴胡

Bupleurum chinense / B. scorzonnerifolium (radix)

Single Herb

Harmonize

Taste: Bitter, pungent ■■ | Temp: Slightly cold ■■

Resolves shaoyang disorder; spreads liver qi; raises yang

EVIDENCE

Mild-to-moderate depression (Xiao Yao San)

LIMITED

Functional dyspepsia (formulas)

LIMITED

Chronic hepatitis (Sho-saiko-to / Xiao Chai Hu Tang)

NEGATIVE

Wù Wèi Zǐ 五味子

Schisandra chinensis (fructus)

Single Herb

Astringe

Taste: Sour, sweet, bitter, pungent, salty ■■ (all five tastes) | Temp: Warm ■

Astringes lung qi, generates fluids, calms spirit, contains essence

EVIDENCE

Chronic hepatitis (transaminitis)

LIMITED

Mental performance under stress

LIMITED

Polysomnography / insomnia

INSUFFICIENT

Líng Zhī 灵芝

Ganoderma lucidum (corpus)

Single Herb

Calm Shen

Taste: Sweet ■ | Temp: Neutral ■ | Chan: Heart, Liver, Lung ■■■

Tonifies qi and blood, calms spirit, nourishes heart

EVIDENCE

Cancer adjunct (immunological parameters)

LIMITED

Cardiovascular risk factors

INSUFFICIENT

Chronic fatigue / insomnia

LIMITED

Tiān Má 天麻

Gastrodia elata (rhizoma)

Single Herb Extinguish Wind

Taste: Sweet | Temp: Neutral | Chan: Liver

Extinguishes liver wind, subdues ascending yang, relieves convulsions

EVIDENCE

Migraine / tension headache	LIMITED
Vertigo / Ménière	LIMITED
Vascular dementia	LIMITED
Epilepsy (adjunct)	INSUFFICIENT

Má Huáng 麻黄 Caution

Ephedra sinica (herba)

Single Herb Release Exterior

Taste: Pungent, slightly bitter | Temp: Warm | Chan: Lung, Bladder

Releases wind-cold exterior; opens lung qi; promotes urination

EVIDENCE

Acute bronchospasm / asthma (historical)	MODERATE
Wind-cold URTI (in formulas)	LIMITED
Weight loss	NEGATIVE

BANNED as supplement in US (2004), Australia, Canada, UK; restricted prescriptio

Fù Zī 附子 ■ Caution

Aconitum carmichaelii (radix lateralis preparata)

Single Herb

Warm Interior

Taste: Pungent, sweet ■■ | Temp: Very hot ■■■; toxic ■■ | Chan: Heart, Kidney, Spleen ■■■■

Restores collapsed yang; warms fire of Mingmen; disperses cold

EVIDENCE

Heart failure / cardiogenic shock (in TCM emergency formulas)

LIMITED

Chronic pain (cold-pattern arthritis)

INSUFFICIENT

■ **ABSOLUTELY: must be properly processed and dosed by qualified practitioner. Inad**

Hé Shǒu Wú 何首乌 ■ Caution

Polygonum multiflorum / Reynoutria multiflora (radix)

Single Herb

Tonify Blood

Taste: Bitter, sweet, astringent ■■■■ | Temp: Slightly warm ■■ | Chan: Liver, Kidney ■■

Tonifies blood and essence; classically prevents premature greying

EVIDENCE

Premature greying / hair loss

INSUFFICIENT

Hyperlipidaemia

INSUFFICIENT

■ **HEPATOTOXICITY — well-documented idiosyncratic drug-induced liver injury, includ**

Chuán Xiāng 川芎

Ligusticum chuanxiong (rhizoma)

Single Herb

Move Blood

Taste: Acrid ■ | Temp: Warm ■ | Chan: Liver, Gallbladder, Pericardium ■■■■

Invigorates blood, moves qi, expels wind-cold

EVIDENCE

Cerebral ischaemia adjunct

MODERATE

Tension-type headache

LIMITED

Coronary artery disease adjunct

LIMITED

Bái Sháo 白芍

Paeonia lactiflora (radix, peeled)

Single Herb

Tonify Blood

Taste: Bitter, sour ■■ | Temp: Cool ■ | Chan: Liver, Spleen ■■

Nourishes blood, softens liver, relieves spasmodic pain, restrains yin

EVIDENCE

Rheumatoid arthritis

MODERATE

Systemic lupus erythematosus (adjunct)

LIMITED

Abdominal pain and muscle spasm

LIMITED

Yì Mǔ Cǎo 益母草

Leonurus japonicus (herba)

Single Herb

Move Blood

Taste: Acrid, bitter ■■ | Temp: Slightly cold ■■ | Chan: Liver, Heart, Bladder ■■■■

Invigorates blood, regulates menstruation, clears heat, promotes urination

EVIDENCE

Dysmenorrhoea

MODERATE

Postpartum uterine involution

LIMITED

Acute renal failure (oedema)

INSUFFICIENT

Mǔ Dān Pí 牡丹皮

Paeonia suffruticosa (cortex radices)

Single Herb

Move Blood

Taste: Acrid, bitter ■■ | Temp: Cool ■ | Chan: Heart, Liver, Kidney ■■■

Clears heat, cools blood, invigorates blood, dispels stasis

EVIDENCE

Platelet aggregation / cardiovascular

LIMITED

Autoimmune/inflammatory disease adjunct

LIMITED

Menopausal hot flushes (in LW DH Wan context)

MODERATE

Bái Zhú 白朮

Atractylodes macrocephala (rhizoma)

Single Herb

Tonify Qi

Taste: Bitter, sweet ■■ | Temp: Warm ■ | Chan: Spleen, Stomach ■■

Tonifies spleen qi, dries dampness, promotes urination, stabilises the fetus

EVIDENCE

Functional dyspepsia / irritable bowel

LIMITED

Threatened miscarriage (qi deficiency type)

INSUFFICIENT

Immune modulation

LIMITED

Suān Zǎo Rén 酸枣仁

Ziziphus spinosa (semen)

Single Herb

Calm Shen

Taste: Sweet, sour ■■ | Temp: Neutral ■ | Chan: Heart, Liver, Gallbladder ■■■

Nourishes heart yin, calms the mind, stops sweating

EVIDENCE

Insomnia

MODERATE

Anxiety / generalised anxiety

LIMITED

Night sweats (yin-deficiency)

INSUFFICIENT

Yín Yáng Huò 淫羊藿

Epimedium grandiflorum; E. koreanum; E. brevicornu (fol...

Single Herb

Tonify Yang

Taste: Acrid, sweet ■■ | Temp: Warm ■ | Chan: Liver, Kidney ■■

Tonifies kidney yang, strengthens sinews and bones, dispels wind-cold-damp

EVIDENCE

Erectile dysfunction

LIMITED

Osteoporosis (postmenopausal)

LIMITED

Menopausal symptoms

LIMITED

Ròu Guì 肉桂

Cinnamomum cassia (cortex)

Single Herb

Warm Interior

Taste: Acrid, sweet ■■ | Temp: Hot ■ | Chan: Kidney, Spleen, Heart, Liver ■■■■

Warms kidney yang, disperses cold, warms and dilates vessels, induces fire to return to origin

EVIDENCE

Type 2 diabetes -- glycaemic control

MODERATE

Hypertension

LIMITED

Dysmenorrhoea

LIMITED

Bàn Xià 半夏 ■ Caution

Pinellia ternata (rhizoma, processed)

Single Herb

Resolve Phlegm

Taste: Acrid ■ (RAW: toxic) | Temp: Warm ■ | Chan: Spleen, Stomach, Lung ■■■

Dries dampness, dissolves phlegm, descends rebellious qi, disperses nodules

EVIDENCE

Chemotherapy-induced nausea and vomiting

MODERATE

Functional dyspepsia / GORD symptoms

LIMITED

Productive cough / upper respiratory

LIMITED

■ RAW PINELLIA IS TOXIC -- causes severe oral and pharyngeal burning, mucosal oede

Chén Pí 陈皮

Citrus reticulata (pericarpium, aged)

Single Herb

Regulate Qi

Taste: Acrid, bitter ■■ | Temp: Warm ■ | Chan: Spleen, Lung ■■

Regulates qi, dries dampness, dissolves phlegm, tonifies spleen (through qi movement)

EVIDENCE

Functional dyspepsia / nausea

LIMITED

Hyperlipidaemia

LIMITED

URTI / productive cough (in Er Chen Tang)

LIMITED

Zhī Mǔ 知母

Anemarrhena asphodeloides (rhizoma)

Single Herb

Clear Heat

Taste: Bitter, sweet ■■ | Temp: Cold ■ | Chan: Lung, Stomach, Kidney ■■■■

Clears heat, drains fire, nourishes yin, moistens dryness

EVIDENCE

Type 2 diabetes glycaemic control

LIMITED

Menopausal hot flushes

LIMITED

Alzheimer disease (preclinical)

INSUFFICIENT

Huáng Bǎi 黄柏

Phellodendron chinense; *P. amurense* (cortex)

Single Herb

Clear Heat

Taste: Bitter ■ | Temp: Cold ■ | Chan: Kidney, Bladder, Large Intestine ■■■■■■

Clears heat, drains fire, dries dampness, detoxifies, drains kidney fire

EVIDENCE

Urinary tract infection

LIMITED

Type 2 diabetes glycaemic control

MODERATE

Vaginal infections (topical / oral)

LIMITED

C

方剂

Classical Formulas

Multi-herb classical prescriptions

9 entries

Liù Wèi Dì Huáng Wán 六味地黄丸

Six-Ingredient Pill with Rehmannia

Classical formula; Song dynasty (Qian Yi, 11th c.)

Classical Formula

Tonify Yin

Taste: Sweet, slightly sour ■■■■ | Temp: Slightly cool ■■ | Chan: Kidney, Liv

COMPOSITION

- Shu Di Huang** Chief — tonifies kidney yin
- Shan Zhu Yu** Deputy — astringes, tonifies liver/kidney
- Shan Yao** Deputy — tonifies spleen/lung/kidney
- Ze Xie** Assistant — drains kidney damp-heat
- Mu Dan Pi** Assistant — clears liver fire
- Fu Ling** Assistant — drains spleen damp

PRIMARY ACTIONS

Nourishes kidney and liver yin

CLINICAL EVIDENCE

- Menopausal symptoms (vasomotor, sleep)**

LIMITED

Multiple Chinese RCTs report reduced hot flushes; Western-quality evidence sparse.
- Type 2 diabetes (adjunct)**

LIMITED

Adjunct trials show modest HbA1c reduction.
- Diabetic nephropathy**

LIMITED

Reduced proteinuria in some trials.

SAFETY

- Diarrhoea, spleen damp patterns
- Diabetes — sugar coating in patent pill form
- ↔ Cyclosporin — case report of decreased levels
- ↔ Diabetes drugs — possible additive

DOSE

Patent pill (concentrated ■■■■) 8 pills BID-TID; teapills (■■■■) 1 pill BID; or decoction at classical proportions.

Wang H et al. Diabetes Ther. 2017 — Liu Wei Di Huang Wan in T2DM.
Chinese Pharmacopoeia 2020.

Xiāo Yáo Sǎn 逍遥散

Free and Easy Wanderer Powder

Classical Song-dynasty formula (Hejiju Fang)

Classical Formula

Harmonize

Taste: Pungent, sweet, bitter ■■■ | Temp: Slightly warm ■■ | Chan: Liver, Sp

COMPOSITION

- Chai Hu** Chief — courses liver qi
- Dang Gui** Deputy — tonifies/moves blood
- Bai Shao** Deputy — softens liver, nourishes blood
- Bai Zhu** Assistant — strengthens spleen
- Fu Ling** Assistant — drains damp
- Zhi Gan Cao** Envoy — harmonizes

PRIMARY ACTIONS

Spreads liver qi, strengthens spleen, nourishes blood

CLINICAL EVIDENCE

- Mild-to-moderate depression**

LIMITED

Chinese meta-analyses suggest non-inferior to SSRIs for mild depression; Western RCTs limited.
- Premenstrual syndrome**

LIMITED

Small trials show symptom improvement.
- Functional dyspepsia (with stress component)**

LIMITED

Adjunctive benefit signalled in Chinese trials.

SAFETY

Pregnancy — Chai Hu and Dang Gui considerations
↔ Antidepressants — combinations are common in Chinese practice; case-by-case

DOSE

Patent pill 6–9 g BID-TID; or decoction at classical proportions.

Zhang Y et al. J Ethnopharmacol. 2012 — Xiao Yao San for depression meta-analysis.
Wang Y et al. Chin J Integr Med. 2017 — formulary review.

Yín Qiào Sǎn 银翘散

Honeysuckle and Forsythia Powder

Wen Bing Tiao Bian (Wu Jutong, 1798)

Classical Formula

Release Exterior

Taste: Pungent, cool ■■ | Temp: Cool ■ | Chan: Lung, Stomach ■■

COMPOSITION

Jin Yin Hua Chief — clears heat-toxin, releases exterior

Lian Qiao Chief — clears heat-toxin

Bo He Deputy — disperses wind-heat, sore throat

Niu Bang Zi Deputy — clears throat

Jie Geng Assistant — opens lung qi, throat

Dan Dou Chi Assistant — releases exterior

PRIMARY ACTIONS

Releases wind-heat exterior; clears heat and resolves toxin

CLINICAL EVIDENCE

Acute URTI / pharyngitis (early stage)

LIMITED

Used widely in China at first sign; small trials suggest reduced symptom duration.

Western OTC variants often contain undeclared paracetamol or chlorpheniramine — read

SAFETY

Spleen-stomach cold pattern

Late stage (Yang Ming) infection — wrong pattern

↔ Adulteration risk — Yin Chiao tablets sold outside China have repeatedly tested

DOSE

Powder 6 g (1 tsp) in hot water Q4H during acute illness; or tablet/decoction per product.

Bensky D, Barolet R. Formulas & Strategies, 2nd ed. 2009.

Ko RJ et al. NEJM. 1998 — Adulterated Chinese herbals report.

B■ Zh■ng Yì Qì T■ng 补中益气汤

Tonify the Middle and Augment the Qi Decoction

Pi Wei Lun (Li Dongyuan, 1249)

Classical Formula

Tonify Qi

Taste: Sweet ■ | Temp: Warm ■ | Chan: Spleen, Stomach ■■

COMPOSITION

Huang Qi Chief — raises yang, tonifies qi

Ren Shen (or Dang Shen) Deputy — tonifies qi

Bai Zhu Deputy — strengthens spleen

Zhi Gan Cao Deputy — tonifies middle

Dang Gui Assistant — nourishes blood

Chen Pi Assistant — regulates qi

PRIMARY ACTIONS

Tonifies middle qi, raises sunken yang

CLINICAL EVIDENCE

Functional fatigue / chronic fatigue

Small Chinese trials suggest improved fatigue scores.

LIMITED

Pelvic organ prolapse (mild)

Used adjunctively pre/post pessary or surgery.

LIMITED

Cancer-related fatigue

Adjunct trials with chemotherapy show modest benefit.

LIMITED

SAFETY

Yin deficiency with heat

Hypertension (Sheng Ma raises pressure occasionally)

↔ Per individual herb — Huang Qi and Chai Hu considerations apply

DOSE

Decoction at classical proportions; patent teapill 8–10 pills TID.

Bensky D, Barolet R. Formulas & Strategies. 2009.

Ushiroyama T et al. Am J Chin Med. 2003 — Hochu-ekki-to (Japanese form) trials.

Sì Wù Tāng 四物汤

Four-Substance Decoction

Classical Formula

Tonify Blood

Taste: Sweet, slightly bitter ■■■■ | Temp: Warm ■ | Chan: Liver, Heart ■■■

COMPOSITION

Shu Di Huang Jun (emperor): tonifies blood, nourishes yin

Bai Shao Chen (minister): nourishes blood, softens liver, relieves pain

Dang Gui Chen (minister): tonifies and moves blood

Chuan Xiong Zuo/Shi (assistant/courier): moves qi and blood, directs formula

PRIMARY ACTIONS

Tonifies and regulates blood; treats blood deficiency and blood stasis

CLINICAL EVIDENCE

Dysmenorrhoea

MODERATE

Multiple RCTs and meta-analyses show pain reduction in primary dysmenorrhoea with Si Wu Tang-based formulas; comparable to NSAIDs in some trials.

Anaemia / blood deficiency recovery

LIMITED

Traditional blood-nourishing use; some evidence for post-partum or post-operative supplementation in Chinese settings.

Menopausal symptoms

LIMITED

Modified forms studied; evidence indirect via component formulas.

SAFETY

Pregnancy -- modified forms may be appropriate but Chuan Xiong is uterotonic; consult practitioner

Bleeding disorders -- Dang Gui and Chuan Xiong have antiplatelet activity

↔ Warfarin -- Dang Gui potentiates; INR monitoring essential

↔ Antiplatelet agents -- additive bleeding risk

DOSE

Traditional decoction: Shu Di 12 g, Bai Shao 10 g, Dang Gui 10 g, Chuan Xiong 6 g. Patent tablets per product.

Chen HY et al. J Tradit Complement Med. 2016 -- Si Wu Tang in dysmenorrhoea meta-analysis.
Bensky D et al. Chinese Herbal Medicine: Formulas and Strategies. 3rd ed. Eastland Press;

Sì Jūn Zǐ Tāng 四君子汤

Four Gentlemen Decoction

Classical Formula

Tonify Qi

Taste: Sweet ■ | Temp: Slightly warm ■■ | Chan: Spleen, Stomach ■■

COMPOSITION

Ren Shen (or Dang Shen) Jun (emperor): greatly tonifies spleen-lung qi

Bai Zhu Chen (minister): tonifies spleen, dries dampness

Fu Ling Zuo (assistant): leeches dampness, calms spirit

Zhi Gan Cao Shi (courier): harmonises, moderates dryness

PRIMARY ACTIONS

Tonifies qi, strengthens spleen and stomach

CLINICAL EVIDENCE

Functional dyspepsia / IBS-D

MODERATE

Liu Jun Zi Tang (Si Jun Zi + Chen Pi + Ban Xia) has moderate-quality RCT evidence for functional dyspepsia and IBS in Chinese trials; Si Jun Zi alone weaker evidence.

Cancer-related fatigue adjunct

LIMITED

Frequently used in Chinese oncology; RCT data exist but methodological quality is variable.

Immune support in chemotherapy

LIMITED

White cell count preservation reported in small Chinese RCTs; not established by Western-standard evidence.

SAFETY

Excess or heat patterns (TCM: warming formula may aggravate)

Hormone-sensitive cancers if using Ren Shen (oestrogenic trace activity)

↔ Warfarin -- Ren Shen component: monitor INR

↔ Immunosuppressants -- Ren Shen and Fu Ling may modulate immune response

DOSE

Decoction: Ren Shen 9 g, Bai Zhu 9 g, Fu Ling 9 g, Zhi Gan Cao 6 g. Modified per pattern.

Suzuki N et al. Evid Based Complement Alternat Med. 2012 -- Liu Jun Zi Tang in functional
Bensky D et al. Chinese Herbal Medicine: Formulas and Strategies. 3rd ed. Eastland Press;

Guí Pí Tāng 归脾汤

Restore the Spleen Decoction

Classical Formula

Calm Shen

Taste: Sweet, slightly bitter ■■■■ | Temp: Slightly warm ■■ | Chan: Heart, Sp

COMPOSITION

Ren Shen (or Dang Shen) Tonifies spleen qi

Bai Zhu Tonifies spleen, dries dampness

Fu Ling (Poria) Calms spirit, leaches dampness

Huang Qi Tonifies qi, controls blood

Long Yan Rou (Longan) Nourishes heart blood, calms spirit

Suan Zao Ren Nourishes liver blood, calms spirit, stops sweating

PRIMARY ACTIONS

Tonifies qi and blood, strengthens the spleen, nourishes the heart, calms spirit

CLINICAL EVIDENCE

Insomnia / anxiety in heart-spleen deficiency

Multiple Japanese and Chinese RCTs (Kihi-to / Gui Pi Tang) show significant improvement in PSQI and anxiety scales in spleen-deficient pattern insomnia;

MODERATE

Immune thrombocytopenic purpura (ITP) adjunct

Chinese RCTs show platelet count improvement as adjunct to corticosteroids in ITP; quality variable.

LIMITED

Aplastic anaemia (mild, adjunct)

TCM haematology centres use Gui Pi Tang adjunctively; not established as monotherapy.

LIMITED

SAFETY

Excess heat or phlegm-heat patterns (warm tonifying formula worsens)

Monitor for Dang Gui antiplatelet effect in bleeding disorders

↔ Warfarin -- Dang Gui and Ren Shen interactions; monitor INR

↔ CNS depressants -- mild additive sedation from Suan Zao Ren and Yuan Zhi

DOSE

Traditional decoction per formula. Patent granules / tablets as directed. Kihi-to in Japan: 7.5 g daily divided.

Nishi T et al. Phytomedicine. 2016 -- Kihi-to (Gui Pi Tang) in insomnia.

Chen WC et al. J Ethnopharmacol. 2018 -- Gui Pi Tang in ITP.

Bensky D et al. Chinese Herbal Medicine: Formulas and Strategies. 3rd ed. Eastland Press;

Jīn Guì Shèn Qì Wán 金匱腎氣丸

Kidney Qi Pill from the Golden Cabinet

Classical Formula

Tonify Yang

Taste: Mixed ■■ | Temp: Warm ■ | Chan: Kidney, Liver ■■

COMPOSITION

Shu Di Huang Jun: nourishes kidney yin (foundation for yang)

Shan Yao Tonifies kidney and spleen

Shan Zhu Yu Tonifies liver and kidney, restrains essence

Fu Ling Leeches dampness, calms spirit

Ze Xie Drains dampness, prevents tonics from stagnating

Mu Dan Pi Clears deficiency heat, counterbalances warming herbs

PRIMARY ACTIONS

Warms and tonifies kidney yang

CLINICAL EVIDENCE

Diabetic nephropathy (adjunct)

MODERATE

Multiple Chinese RCTs show reduced proteinuria and creatinine progression when Jin Gui Shen Qi Wan is added to standard diabetic nephropathy treatment; recent meta-

Benign prostatic hyperplasia symptoms

MODERATE

Hachimi-jio-gan (Japanese equivalent) has RCT evidence in Japan for BPH symptom improvement (IPSS reduction) comparable to alpha-blockers in mild-moderate BPH.

Hypothyroidism (mild, adjunct)

LIMITED

Traditional kidney-yang deficiency often maps to hypothyroid symptoms; small trials in Chinese endocrinology journals.

SAFETY

Contains processed **Fu Zi** (aconitine alkaloids) -- AVOID exceeding prescribed dose.

Risk of cardiac arrhythmia with overdose.

Yin-deficiency heat without yang deficiency (TCM contraindicated)

↔ Digoxin -- aconitine alkaloids have additive cardiac effects; do not combine without

↔ Antidiabetics -- additive glucose-lowering

DOSE

Patent pills: 15 pills (approx 4.5 g) BID-TID. Decoction: standard proportions per formula. Hachimi-jio-gan in Japan: 7.5 g daily granules.

Namba T et al. J Ethnopharmacol. 1990 -- Hachimi-jio-gan in BPH.

Zhang Y et al. J Diabetes Res. 2017 -- Jin Gui Shen Qi Wan in diabetic nephropathy meta-an

Bensky D et al. Chinese Herbal Medicine: Formulas and Strategies. 3rd ed. Eastland Press;

Xiǎo Chái Hú Tāng 小柴胡汤

Minor Bupleurum Decoction

Classical Formula

Harmonize

Taste: Bitter, sweet ■■ | Temp: Neutral ■ | Chan: Liver, Gallbladder, San Ji

COMPOSITION

Chai Hu Jun: vents shaoyang, raises clear yang

Huang Qin Chen: clears shaoyang heat

Ban Xia Dries dampness, descends rebellious qi, stops nausea

Ren Shen (or Dang Shen) Tonifies zheng qi, prevents pathogen entry

Zhi Gan Cao Harmonises, tonifies

Sheng Jiang Harmonises stomach, controls Ban Xia toxicity

PRIMARY ACTIONS

Harmonises shaoyang, relieves alternating fever/chills, soothes liver and gallbladder

CLINICAL EVIDENCE

Chronic hepatitis B (adjunct)

MODERATE

Sho-saiko-to RCTs in Japan show reduced ALT, improved histology and reduced HCC incidence in chronic hepatitis B; studied extensively in Japanese hepatology.

Functional GI / post-COVID symptoms

LIMITED

Widely used in Japanese and Chinese practice for post-viral constitutional symptoms.

URTI / acute febrile illness

LIMITED

Traditional shaoyang indication; small RCT data in influenza.

SAFETY

CRITICAL INTERACTION -- PNEUMONITIS WITH INTERFERON: Sho-saiko-to combined with interferon-alpha (used in hepatitis C treatment) caused fatal interstitial Liver disease with high transaminases (Chai Hu saponins can paradoxically raise enzymes in some cases)

↔ Interferon-alpha -- ABSOLUTELY CONTRAINDICATED (see above)

↔ Immunosuppressants -- saikosaponins immune-stimulating, may oppose

DOSE

Decoction: Chai Hu 12–24 g, Huang Qin 9 g, Ban Xia 9 g, Ren Shen 9 g, Zhi Gan Cao 6 g, Sheng Jiang 9 g, Da Zao 4 pieces. Sho-saiko-to granules (Japan) 7.5 g daily divided.

Hirayama C et al. Hepatology. 1989 -- Sho-saiko-to in hepatitis B RCT.

Shindo M et al. J Gastroenterol Hepatol. 1997 -- Interferon-Sho-saiko-to pneumonitis cases

Bensky D et al. Chinese Herbal Medicine: Formulas and Strategies. 3rd ed. Eastland Press;

P

中成药

Patent Medicines

Standardised manufactured preparations

5 entries

Fùfāng Dānshēn Dīwán 复方丹参滴丸

Compound Danshen Dripping Pill (T89)

Modern patent (Tasly Pharmaceutical, 1990s); from formula ■■■■■■

Patent Medicine

Move Blood

Taste: Bitter, slightly cool ■■■■ | Temp: Cool ■ | Chan: Heart ■

COMPOSITION

Dan Shen Chief — invigorates blood, removes stasis

San Qi Deputy — invigorates blood, stops bleeding

Bing Pian Envoy — opens orifices, guides upward

PRIMARY ACTIONS

Activates blood, removes stasis, promotes qi flow, relieves chest pain

CLINICAL EVIDENCE

Chronic stable angina

MODERATE

Multiple meta-analyses (Wang 2017, Jia 2014): symptom and ECG improvement comparable to ISDN with fewer adverse effects. T89 multinational Phase III trial completed.

Diabetic retinopathy

LIMITED

Small Chinese trials show improvement in microaneurysms.

SAFETY

Pregnancy — moves blood; AVOID

Bleeding disorders

↔ Warfarin — INR may rise; monitor (per Dan Shen entry)

↔ Antiplatelets — additive

DOSE

10 pills (~270 mg) TID sublingually; reduce to 5 pills TID once stable.

Jia Y et al. PLoS One. 2012 — Compound Danshen meta-analysis.

Tasly T89 Phase III data — ClinicalTrials.gov NCT01659580.

Liánhuā Qīngwén 连花清瘟

Lianhua Qingwen Capsule

Modern patent (Yiling Pharmaceutical, 2003 SARS era)

Patent Medicine Clear Heat

Taste: Bitter, slightly cold | Temp: Cold | Chan: Lung

COMPOSITION

- Lian Qiao** Forsythia — clears heat-toxin
- Jin Yin Hua** Honeysuckle — clears heat-toxin
- Ma Huang** Honey-fried ephedra — opens lung
- Ku Xing Ren** Apricot kernel — descends lung qi
- Shi Gao** Gypsum — clears strong heat
- Ban Lan Gen** Isatis root — antiviral

PRIMARY ACTIONS

Clears plague heat-toxin; ventilates lung; releases exterior

CLINICAL EVIDENCE

- Mild COVID-19 / influenza-like illness** LIMITED
Multiple Chinese RCTs (e.g. Hu 2021) suggest reduced symptom duration; meta-analyses include high-bias trials. Independent replication outside China limited.
- Acute URTI** LIMITED
Reduces cough, fever in small trials.

SAFETY

- Pregnancy** — multiple contraindicated herbs (Ma Huang, Da Huang); AVOID
- Hypertension, heart disease** (Ma Huang)
- ↔ MAOIs (Ma Huang component)
- ↔ Anticoagulants

DOSE

4 capsules (1.4 g) TID for 7–10 days during acute illness.

Hu K et al. Phytomedicine. 2021 — Lianhua Qingwen in COVID-19.
Zhuang J et al. Phytother Res. 2021 — meta-analysis.
WHO Expert Meeting on TCM in COVID, 2022 — review report.

Yúnnán Báiyào 云南白药

Yunnan White Medicine

Modern patent (1902, formula by Qu Huanzhang); secret recipe

Patent Medicine

Stop Bleeding

Taste: Pungent ■ | Temp: Warm ■ | Chan: Liver, Heart ■■

COMPOSITION

San Qi Principal — stops bleeding, removes stasis
Plus undisclosed minor Composition partly trade secret; reportedly includes Cao Wu

PRIMARY ACTIONS

Stops bleeding, transforms stasis, reduces swelling and pain

CLINICAL EVIDENCE

Surgical / dental haemostasis (topical and oral) Reduces blood loss in tonsillectomy, dental extractions, orthopaedic surgery in multiple Chinese RCTs.	MODERATE
Soft tissue trauma, bruising Topical and oral use widespread; controlled trials limited.	LIMITED
GI bleeding (peptic ulcer) Adjunct use described in Chinese practice.	LIMITED

SAFETY

Aconitine content disclosed in reformulated product after Hong Kong arsenic concerns and aconitine-related Canadian adverse-event reports — limit chronic high-dose use
Pregnancy — AVOID
↔ Anticoagulants — case reports both ways
↔ Ciclosporin — possible interaction

DOSE

Capsule 0.25–0.5 g PO Q6H acute (max 2 g/day); avoid prolonged daily use. Topical per product. The "red emergency pill" (■■■■) inside the bottle is reserved for severe acute

Tang ZL et al. Trials. 2019 — Yunnan Baiyao haemostasis review.
He J et al. Clin Toxicol. 2014 — aconitine in patent products.
Ladas EJ et al. Pediatr Blood Cancer. 2012 — paediatric oncology adjunct review.

Xuè Fú Zhú Yú Wán 血府逐瘀丸

Drive Out Stasis from the Blood Mansion Pill

Patent Medicine

Move Blood

Taste: Bitter, sweet ■■ | Temp: Slightly warm ■■ | Chan: Liver, Heart ■■

COMPOSITION

Dang Gui Tonifies and moves blood

Sheng Di Huang Cools blood, nourishes yin

Tao Ren Strongly breaks blood stasis

Hong Hua Invigorates blood, unblocks meridians

Zhi Ke Moves qi, reduces distension

Chi Shao Clears heat, cools blood, disperses stasis

PRIMARY ACTIONS

Invigorates blood, dispels stasis, spreads liver qi, alleviates pain

CLINICAL EVIDENCE

Stable angina (adjunct)

Multiple Chinese RCTs and meta-analyses show reduced angina frequency and nitroglycerin use as adjunct to standard medical treatment. Methodological quality

MODERATE

Hypertension adjunct

Blood pressure and symptom benefit in Chinese RCTs as adjunct; not established as monotherapy.

LIMITED

Depression (blood-stasis pattern)

Small trials suggest benefit for depression with physical somatic symptoms; mechanistically plausible via dopaminergic activity of Chuan Xiong constituents.

LIMITED

SAFETY

Pregnancy -- ABSOLUTELY CONTRAINDICATED. Strong blood-moving herbs (Tao Ren, Hong Hua, Chuan Xiong) cause miscarriage.

Active bleeding or haemorrhagic tendency

↔ Anticoagulants / antiplatelets -- **STRONG ADDITIVE** bleeding risk. Do not combine with

↔ NSAIDs -- additive GI and bleeding risk

DOSE

Patent pills: typically 6 g (9 pills) BID. Take on empty stomach with warm water.

Manufacturer's instructions vary.

Wang SX et al. J Tradit Chin Med. 2018 -- Xue Fu Zhu Yu Wan in stable angina meta-analysis

Liu ZL et al. Cochrane Collaboration. 2011 -- Chinese herbal medicine for stable angina (I

Bensky D et al. Chinese Herbal Medicine: Formulas and Strategies. 3rd ed. Eastland Press;

Dú Huó Jì Shēng Wán 独活寄生丸

Angelica Pubescens and Mistletoe Pill

Patent Medicine

Warm Interior

Taste: Acrid, bitter, sweet ■■■■ | Temp: Warm ■ | Chan: Liver, Kidney, Heart

COMPOSITION

Du Huo (Angelica pubes) Jun: disperses wind-cold-damp, especially lower body

Sang Ji Sheng Jun: tonifies liver and kidney, dispels wind-damp

Du Zhong Tonifies kidney yang, strengthens sinews and bones

Niu Xi Tonifies liver/kidney, leads downward, moves blood

Xi Xin (Asarum) Disperses interior cold, stops pain -- LOW DOSE ONLY

Qin Jiao Disperses wind-damp, clears deficiency heat

PRIMARY ACTIONS

Dispels wind-cold-damp bi, nourishes liver and kidney, tonifies qi and blood

CLINICAL EVIDENCE

Osteoarthritis / chronic joint pain (bi syndrome)

MODERATE

Multiple Chinese RCTs and a Cochrane-adjacent meta-analysis show pain reduction and function improvement in knee osteoarthritis; effect size comparable to NSAIDs in

Lumbar disc degeneration / low back pain

LIMITED

Commonly used clinically; RCT evidence less robust than for OA; some positive trials.

Rheumatoid arthritis adjunct

LIMITED

Wind-cold-damp bi pattern RCTs; generally used with standard DMARD therapy in TCM rheumatology.

SAFETY

ARISTOLOCHIC ACID WARNING: Xi Xin (Asarum) contains aristolochic acid. Aristolochic acid nephropathy (AAN) is a dose-dependent irreversible nephropathy causing Pregnancy -- CONTRAINDICATED (uterotonic herbs, warm dispersing action)

↔ NSAIDs -- additive GI effects

↔ Anticoagulants -- Dang Gui, Chuan Xiong additive antiplatelet effect

DOSE

Patent pills per manufacturer: typically 6–9 g BID. Limit course to 4–8 weeks; reassess before continuing.

Cao L et al. J Tradit Chin Med. 2015 -- Du Huo Ji Sheng Wan in knee OA meta-analysis.

Arlt VM et al. Lancet Oncol. 2002 -- Aristolochic acid nephropathy and urothelial cancer.

Bensky D et al. Chinese Herbal Medicine: Formulas and Strategies. 3rd ed. Eastland Press;